

Chapter 86-1 - Background

Wushan¹ was several thousand li away from Penglai. Because Xiangliu would attract Penglai's pursuing soldiers and couldn't be ridden for long, Baili Shiqi put away Xiangliu halfway through their journey and used magical artifacts to conceal the demonic qi on its body.

Since Jiuying and Ning Fuyi had difficulty controlling their swords, they could only ride in magical artifact carriages from Baili Shiqi's pouch and travel by land. This conveniently allowed them to avoid the pursuing soldiers flying all over the sky from Penglai, though it required going around mountains and water, lengthening their journey.

Ning Fuyi and Jiuying basically never left the carriage the entire way. Because both were injured by Penglai's divine artifacts and didn't dare seek medical immortals, they could only use pills Baili Shiqi carried to heal their injuries. So while they weren't in mortal danger, their internal injuries remained difficult to cure.

On the eighth day after leaving Penglai, they finally reached a town near Wushan, disguising themselves as travelers and blending into the town.

It had been nearly a month since that day of great upheaval. The autumn colors had grown more intense, with red, yellow, and green foliage along the road, dyeing the originally blue mountains and rivers in rich, heavy colors. Combined with the treacherous terrain near Wushan, with its towering peaks and highest points capped with white snow, it seemed one could see all four seasons with a single glance.

Even the town was built following the mountain's contours, rising and falling with the mountain's flow, creating a feeling of being hidden in the wilderness yet situated in a bustling marketplace.

"Sister Ning, I don't see any Penglai pursuing soldiers here. You can relax a bit," Baili Shiqi whispered in Ning Fuyi's ear.

The three of them had all changed their appearances using Baili Shiqi's divine artifacts to look completely ordinary, making them quite inconspicuous among the bustling crowds.

"Don't let your guard down. We've encountered Penglai immortal soldiers everywhere along our journey, so why are there suddenly no pursuing soldiers at Wushan? Jiang Li was familiar with me at Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate. The most likely places for me to seek refuge after escaping from Penglai would be the Jiang family² and the Liu family³. I'm sure the Penglai people have already set up ambushes here, waiting for us to arrive," Ning Fuyi replied in a low voice.

She scanned the roadside vendors and pointed to two dressed most cleanly: "Look there."

"You're right - those are Penglai immortal soldier markings. I can see them," Baili Shiqi said with wide eyes.

"I told you those Penglai demi-gods are all no good, using underhanded tactics everywhere. Even the demon clan isn't as bad as them," Jiuying nearby whispered angrily.

Baili Shiqi tugged at her fingers and looked at her. Only then did Jiuying close her mouth: "Sorry, I forgot you're also from Penglai."

Wushan was difficult to climb, so they first found an inconspicuous tavern by the roadside to discuss how to meet Jiang Li. However, just as they sat down, they saw several Eastern Mountain⁴ people at the neighboring table drinking until their faces were red and necks thick, speaking carelessly about something.

The most handsome-looking one gulped down two mouthfuls of wine, wiped his mouth and said: "Brothers, do you think I can see the legendary Jiang family head on this journey of thousands of li to Wushan, and ask her to detoxify us?"

Another short, thin man holding his wine bowl shook his head: "Brother, the Jiang family head Jiang Wuying⁵? The Jiang family head has been bedridden for decades. Forget about you - even if Emperor Tianrui⁶ came now, he couldn't move the old lady."

"If you really want to seek help, you can only find Young Master Jiang Li. But this Jiang Li was severely injured when fighting the demon clan before and is also recuperating in bed. The two people with the highest medical skills in the Jiang family won't come out. I think you should just go back."

Hearing this, the handsome man became so anxious that tears welled up: "But I'm poisoned by a venomous tail demon. Only medical immortals with the highest skills can save me. If I can't get help from these two, what can I do?"

Ning Fuyi and Jiuying exchanged glances, secretly communicating: "It seems we can't directly seek an audience with Jiang Li. We need to think of another way to see her."

At this point, the people at the neighboring table also heard the man's words and turned around laughing: "Little brother, I have a method that might be worth trying."

"What method?" the man asked, sniffing.

"This Jiang family head has been bedridden for many years and probably doesn't have much time left. So she's sent invitations throughout the world, saying she wants to recruit a son-in-law for Young Master Jiang Li⁷. Anyone selected has a chance to meet Jiang Li. Looking at your handsome appearance and tall figure, you might want to try. Maybe you'll catch her eye, and then you won't have to worry about anyone detoxifying you!"

"Son-in-law?" The man looked extremely embarrassed and waved his hands repeatedly: "This brother doesn't know - I'm an Eastern Mountain person who hunts beasts for a living, sleeping outdoors with no fixed home. How could I be worthy of a distinguished young master?"

The person at the neighboring table made a sound and laughed: "What are you panicking about? The Jiang family head has said that this recruitment of a son-in-law doesn't look at family background or wealth, only character and appearance. As long as someone has upright character and good looks, they can apply."

"There's just one restriction - it can only be men, not women."

"Can't be women? How is there such a strange requirement?" The handsome man scratched his head. "This Jiang Li is a woman, so shouldn't she naturally recruit men? Why make such a redundant statement?"

"You don't know - this Young Master Jiang Li used to have someone she loved, apparently her junior sister from when she was studying medicine. The two even secretly pledged themselves to each other behind the family head's back. Later when the matter was exposed, it angered the family head so much that she used severe family punishment, beating Jiang Li until she couldn't get out of bed. In the end, the family head made herself sick from anger but still couldn't separate the two."

"Such a thing happened?" The man was extremely astonished, pulling his companions to change tables, even forgetting about his severe poisoning. "What happened next?"

"What happened next was even more exciting. That junior sister was later investigated and her true identity was discovered - she was actually a black snake demon! The distinguished young master was actually having a romance with a black snake demon - it would make people die laughing if word got out."

The person slapped the table laughing: "Once her identity was exposed, the black snake demon was beaten to death by the Jiang family, and they spent money to cover up the matter, finally settling it."

"Few people in Jianghu⁸ know about this. My distant relative is from a Jiang family branch, which is how I know this inside story." The person wiped his mouth. "If you ask me, this Jiang Li doesn't understand anything. Having romantic feelings for women is all because she's never loved a man. Once she marries a man, she'll come to her senses!"

Ning Fuyi, who had been silently listening to their discussion, tightened her hand and crushed the teacup in her palm.

Jiuying also looked shocked, saying quietly: "So Jiang Li had such a past. I always thought she was one of those healers who renounced love, seeing her always dignified, peaceful, and ethereal."

She looked up to see Ning Fuyi's hands full of hot tea and quickly reached out to stop her: "Don't! We're fugitives now - you can't be impulsive."

However, while she was restraining her on this side, those men on the other side continued speaking without restraint: "I think so too. Those immortals being extraordinary is one thing, but we're all human race after all. Women pairing with men is natural law. Moreover, it was one person and one demon. I think..."

Finally, Jiuying let go of her hand and gave up resisting. Thus Ning Fuyi flicked her wrist, and all the wine pots and dishes in front of those men immediately exploded. The scalding hot food that had just been served splashed all over their faces, and immediately the tavern was filled with screams.

"Talking nonsense," Ning Fuyi slowly wiped the water stains from her palm, placed silver on the table, and left amidst the chaos. "Let's go."

"They're just brainless people. Sister Ning, don't get angry," Baili Shiqi said, dodging the waiters rushing about frantically. "But we haven't discussed how we're going to get into the Jiang family."

"Don't worry," Ning Fuyi lowered her head to avoid the gazes of those heavenly soldiers, her red lips slightly pursed. "I already have a method."

Wushan's Jiang family lived up to its reputation as the foremost medical immortal family. The entire estate was filled with the fragrance of medicinal herbs, and for hundreds of li outside the estate, immortal magic simulated various environments for growing herbs, planted full of various immortal grasses needed for pill refinement.

Jiang family branch members continuously entered and exited the estate carrying medicine boxes to practice medicine down the mountain. Even the immortal attendants tending the herbs carried medical pouches with them, ready for emergencies.

The estate was full of steaming heat from pill refinement everywhere. Only the deepest part remained untouched by human feet, appearing much more desolate.

Footnotes:

1. **Wushan (巫山):** "Witch Mountain" - the location where the Jiang family medical clan resides
2. **Jiang family (江家):** A prominent medical family clan, known for their healing abilities
3. **Liu family (柳家):** Another family clan, likely referring to Liu Wenzhu's family
4. **Eastern Mountain (东岳):** One of the sacred mountains, representing people from the eastern region
5. **Jiang Wuying (江无影):** "Jiang Shadowless" - the current head of the Jiang family
6. **Emperor Tianrui (天瑞帝君):** The ruler of Penglai Realm
7. **Young Master Jiang Li (江离少主):** Jiang Li is referred to with a male title because in this context, she's being treated as the family heir regardless of gender
8. **Jianghu (江湖):** The martial arts/cultivation world community